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Introduction

SPECTACLES

SPECTACLES is an acronym for the Social, Political, Economic, Cultural, Technical, Aesthetic, Customers , Legal, Environmental and Sectoral influences on an organisation and is used to enable an organisation to audit its current environment, assess potential changes and to guide strategic decision-making (Morrison and Daniels, 2010; Cartwright, 2001)

A SPECTACLES analysis is an extension of an analysis technique known originally as PESTLE (Political, Economic, Social, Technical, Legal, Environmental) analysis (Tiernan *et al*., 2006; Griffin, 2008; Hill and Jones, 2009; J Gallagher, 2011; Johnson *et al*., 2011;), which has been used as valuable tool for assessing where the organisation stands in relation to its environment. Carrying out a PESTLE analysis allows an organisation to access the effect of potential changes and place it, in a better position than its competitors, to respond to those changes (Morrison and Daniels, 2010).

As the business environment has become more complex, the limitations of the traditional PESTLE analysis has been extended to incorporate Cultural, Aesthetic, Customer and Sectorial environments, and the acronym has been expanded to SPECTACLES (Cartwright, 2001). A PESTLE analysis is considered to be relevant to an analysis of the macro environment in which a Sample Company operates. The following diagram, adapted from Johnson (2011 p.52) indicates where the SPECTACLES components may impact on the Sample Company

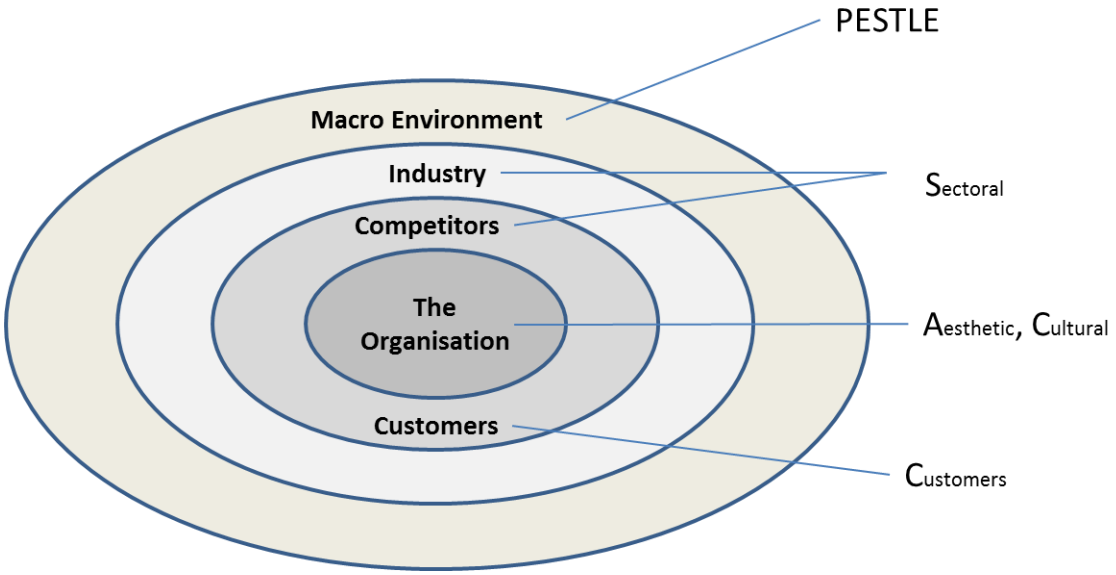


Figure 1: SPECTACLES (adapted from Johnson *et al*., 2011)

Each component of SPECTACLES has been described by many authors (Cartwright, 2001; Tiernan *et al*., 2006; Griffin, 2008; Hill and Jones, 2009; Morrison and Daniels, 2010; Johnson *et al*., 2011; Williams, 2011). This analysis explores each of these components in detail with reference to the impact of each component upon the operations of an Irish software Sample Company, Sample Company TPS (Company). Each section explores one of the SPECTACLES components and provides a commentary on its importance as it relates to Sample Company. Information on the Sample Company was obtained through a structured interview with the Sample Company Managing Director, Mr. MD, and with reference to the author's experience of the Sample Company following an internship during 2010 as part of the requirements for the BBS. (The interview template was drawn from Cartwright (2001), and has been included in Appendix A). In addition, in order to broaden the analysis model where it was felt to be appropriate, the SPECTACLES component in question has been explored in terms of the widely referenced Porters Five Forces model (Johnson *et al*., 2011; Rainer & Cegielski. 2011), which helps to identify how attractive a market is in terms of competitive forces: the threat of entry, the threat of substitutions, the power of buyers, the power of suppliers and the extent of rivalry between competitors.

Analysis by Component

Social

"The social component of the general environment refers to the demographic characteristics, general behaviours, attitudes and beliefs of people in a particular society." (Williams, 2011 p. 149). In particular, how health and safety consciousness, population growth rate, age distribution, career attitudes and attitudes to environmental issues might impact an organisation (Morrison and Daniels, 2010).

Social analysis is concerned with examining the factors which change within the society an organisation interacts with and what trends are likely to have implications for the organisation (Cartwright, 2001). There are two ways in which demographics impact on an organisation - through the workforce employed and the consumers who purchase goods and services (Tiernan *et al*., 2006).

During the last decade Ireland had gone through tremendous social change. Society's expectations had changed and, up until the last three years or so, many were enjoying a higher standard of living than ever before which led to a high degree of quality in peoples personal lives (Morley and Heraty, 2000).

Ireland performs well on many social parameters and has a Human Development Index (HDI) that places it fifth among 182 countries. The country's HDI index is an indicator of the advances in providing basic social services. Ireland has been relatively successful in providing healthcare and education services to its population. Irelands population is considered young in comparison with other EU countries with a median age of 35, with 40% of the population under the age of 25 compared to the European average of around 30% (Ireland: Country Analysis Report, 2010) In addition, while the ethnic mix of people entering Ireland have brought much needed skills, challenges are arising in terms of management of such a diversified workforce. Further, more and more people are working part time and in contract rather than permanent jobs (Gallagher, 2011).

Social conditions have changed in recent years however due to altered economic conditions. Rising unemployment, public sector wage reductions, tax rises and widespread property negative equity, indicates that consumer demand is likely to remain low for the foreseeable future. Irish households are highly indebted and therefore consumption will be constrained as people attempt to deal with personal debt, as credit conditions remain tight in 2011 – 2013 (The Economist Intelligence Unit, 2011).

Social Analysis: Sample Company

Sample Company customers are dispersed over a wide variety of social groupings due to the nature of online business.

The software which has been developed by Sample Company is highly sophisticated and would be regarded as technologically at the leading edge of software development. Staff currently employed in Sample Company is highly educated, with a minimum of third level education considered a necessity in the hiring process. It is anticipated in the future that this hiring standard will remain. Ireland's commitment to the provision of higher education in the past has been a key factor in this regard. Although there has been a slippage in the national expenditure levels attributed to higher education, there is still a steady supply of highly trained software engineering graduates available to Sample Company when they are required, and no difficulty is envisaged in this respect in the medium term. However larger companies, such as Google, have reported that they are unable to find suitably qualified software developers in Ireland and this may become a concern to Sample Company in the medium term.

Current demographic trends in Ireland will have a positive impact on Sample Company. Having such a high percentage of the Irish population under the age of 25 means that many Irish people are extremely IT literate and are familiar with the technology and expertise required to use the Sample Company payment processing system. Resistance to the use of such payment systems is therefore low.

Recent economic conditions have meant that many Irish are losing their jobs and are receiving significant redundancy payments. Paradoxically, despite the slowdown in economic conditions implied by job losses, this factor, combined with the availability of start-up assistance available from the state, has resulted in an increase in the number of small start-up businesses in Ireland. In this respect, the downturn of the last three years has been positive for Sample Company, since there has been an increased demand for the services of Sample Company software among such small start-up companies.

Political

"Politics is the art and science of government and is concerned with those external policy developments that affect the organisation including indigenous political policies and those in national regions of the customers and suppliers" (Cartwright, 2001, p.40). Organisations need to be up-to-date on events in the political environment, particularly in areas such as tax policy, employment laws, environmental regulations, trade restrictions and reform, tariffs and political stability (Morrison and Daniels, 2010).

Political stability is important for business success; no business wants to operate in a country where the government is unstable (Griffin, 2008). The political environment incorporates political stability and risks in doing business in a country. Political risk for an organisation has been defined as the risk of strategic, financial or personal loss "..arising from political forces or Government actions which interfere with, or prevent, foreign business transactions or change the terms of agreements" (Weston and Sorge (1972) in Morley and Heraty, 2000 p. 105). Changes in government policies affect the way in which organisations conduct business and can therefore directly influence decisions made and strategies taken by organisations. (Williams, 2011)

It is not possible to refer to political forces in Ireland without discussing their bearing on regulatory and legal forces (Tiernan *et al*., 2006). Political processes shape the laws, and the interaction between political and legal forces and business is often two-way. The government sets the regulations in which the organisation operates and organisations may seek to influence politicians by providing financial support (Hill and Jones, 2009). On a national level, a government can affect business through its policies in relation to industrial or services development and, in particular, by the tax incentives, capital grants and expansion schemes available (Morley and Heraty, 2000; Tiernan *et al*., 2006).

The Irish political system is headed by the president (Michael D Higgins is President Elect) who acts as nominal head-of-state, is aided by the Council of State, and exercises constitutional powers. The Irish legislative body consists of a 60 member Senate and a 166 member Dail. The Taoiseach, Enda Kenny, is elected by the Dail and serves as Head of Government. Executive powers are invested in the Cabinet, whose ministers are nominated by the Taoiseach and whose seals of office are awarded by the president. Currently the Fine Gael–Labour coalition government is likely to serve its full term to 2016, given its large majority. However, political stability will be significantly tested in the coming years given the current economic situation (Ireland: Country Analysis Report, 2010). The balance of power in the coalition is likely to make agreement on policy positions difficult as Fine Gael is moderately centre right whereas the Labour party is firmly on the left. However, the opposition is

weak and fragmented with the previous government having suffered massive losses at the last general election. A feature of Irish politics has been the inappropriate links between business and politics which contributed to the weaknesses in policy and regulations that have caused the current financial crisis (The Economist Intelligence Unit, 2011).

The key policies of the Irish government are to foster export led growth (Ireland: Country Analysis Report, 2010). Any future major political decisions will be framed by the interests of the EU and IMF, which between them have loaned Ireland €85 billion (Walsh, 2011). The key political and economic challenge which the Irish economy faces currently is that posed by the management of the existing sovereign debt and the impact which this is having, and will continue to have, on the Irish population, both socially and economically (Irish Times Editorial, Oct 28, 2011).

EU countries are required to spend 3% of GDP on research; however, Ireland spends less than 1.5%. of public expenditure as a percentage of GNP on research and development. However, this figure was only 0.66% in 2008, so the country is moving in the right direction at least. The government also increased its expenditure on research in the capital budget which was released in July 2010 (Ireland: Country Analysis Report: 2010)

A low rate of corporation tax has been the foundation of policy in Ireland since the 1950's (Gallagher, 2011). The rate is currently 12.5% for all companies who operate in Ireland. However, both Germany and France have indicated that they would like Ireland to raise its corporation tax in exchange for interest rate reductions on the loans which have been provided to Ireland through the troika of the European Union (EU), the International Monetary Fund (IMF) and the European Central Bank(ECB) (The Economist Intelligence Unit, 2011). These calls for tax harmonisation across Europe would lower the attractiveness of Ireland with regards to foreign direct investment. This low rate is more important than ever as Ireland struggles to reduce its budget deficit, foreign multinational companies will be vital for Ireland's recovery (Gallagher, 2011).

Political Analysis: Sample Company

While the existing political stability within the Irish context is favourable to companies operating within the Irish environment, it is the likely impact of the European political context on Ireland which will give rise to political uncertainty, and potentially undermine such favourable conditions. The key uncertainty lies in the fact that the new deal for European economic stabilisation may require a new treaty which is dependent, in this country, upon the willingness of our population to accede to such a change through referendum. “Recent opinion polls suggest that if there was another EU referendum in this country in the near-to-medium term, then it would be rejected.” (Business & Finance, October 2011). Sample Company are aware of this issue and the potential changes which may emerge should there be a significant adjustment within existing Treaty arrangements.

It is within this economic and political context that companies such as Sample Company are striving to grow their business, which is critically dependent upon consumers’ willingness to conduct economic transactions online. However, lack of consumer faith in the banking regulatory system, the failure of the EU to complete a comprehensive debt management scheme, continues to result in a lack of consumer confidence and therefore has an impact on their willingness to conduct economic activity.

Within the Irish context, Sample Company do not associate themselves with any particular political party as they do not see it as an advantage to their business. Politics only affects their business in relation to any new legislation which may have an effect on their operating costs, potential market or the taxes they may have to pay to the government. In that respect, one of the most significant changes in recent policy was the reduction in VAT on services from 13.5% to 12.5 % in the last budget. This had the effect of reducing the costs of Sample Company’s services to the customer. However, this has had a negative impact on Sample Company cash flow as it increases the effective amount of VAT that Sample Company pays on its own non service purchases.

The trend towards increasing public expenditure on research and development will have a positive effect on Sample Company’s business as it will increase the size of the market that is able to avail of their services and also will allow them apply for grants from the government to develop new ways of using the current services they already offer.

Economic

"The economic environment considers the source of finance for organisations and the effects of regional, national and international economies including exchange rates, interest rates and inflation" (Cartwright, 2011, p.40)

The economic context is shaped by the general state of individual economies, by economic policies pursued by their respective governments and by the economic position of their trading partners (Tiernan *et al*., 2006). The economic dimension is the overall health and vitality of the economic system in which the organisation operates (Griffin, 2008). The current state of a country's economy affects virtually every organisation doing business there (Williams, 2011). Inflation, interest rates and unemployment are important economic factors for organisations (Griffin, 2008). All Governments pursue different economic policies; these affect key areas like inflation, the change in prices levels from one year to the next, wage rates, interest rates and the cost of borrowing money (Morley and Heraty, 2000). Variations in these key areas have important effects on the business environment (Tiernan *et al*., 2006)

A shrinking economy makes growth for individual business difficult (Williams, 2011). Emergence of global interdependencies between different countries is important given that Ireland is a small open economy – no longer do national economies operate in isolation – events in one economy impact on other economies (Tiernan *et al*., 2006)

Ireland is considered the fifth freest economy in the world according to the 2010 Index of economic freedom. The Irish economy has benefited from its openness and flexibility in the past but has recently come under pressure due to a rising budget deficit and national debt. Ireland's overall levels of economic freedom remain high, sustained by strengths like strong protection of property rights, efficient business regulations, and competitive tax rates. Ireland's economy contracted for a third consecutive year in 2010. Exports which were expected to underpin economic recovery grew during 2010 but declined in the fourth quarter and the sluggish recovery of Ireland main exports markets the EU, UK and US, will restrain export growth in the near future (Economist Intelligence Unit, 2011)

Ireland recorded the largest deficit among the 27 European Union Member states in 2009 and given Ireland's huge deficit and high levels and indebtedness in both the private and public sectors there is a risk that Ireland will have difficulties servicing its debt costs. The banking sector in Ireland is in crisis despite recapitalisation, bad asset purchases and liability guarantees. The lax financial control and expansive budgets during the period of economic boom left Ireland highly vulnerable to events such as the global financial crisis (Ireland: Country File, 2010).

After many years of a booming economy the country is now deep in recession which is expected to last for many years (Gallagher, 2011) and, as outlined in the political analysis, economic policy will be determined by the terms agreed by the Irish government, the EU, the IMF and the ECB (Ireland: Country Report, 2011). The key political and economic challenge which the Irish economy faces currently is that posed by the management of the existing sovereign debt and the impact which this is having, and will continue to have, on the Irish population, both socially and economically.

At the time of writing (October 28th, 2011), the European Union has constructed a new deal for the management of overall European debt crises, which is intended to ensure that the economic problems of Greece will not escalate to the point where larger European economies such as Italy and Spain, may become the target of bond market fluctuations. The ultimate goal is to ensure the survival of the Euro. However, the impact of the negotiated deal on Ireland has yet to be assessed (Irish Times Editorial, Oct 28th, 2011).

Economic Analysis: Sample Company

It is within this economic and political context that companies such as Sample Company are striving to grow their business, which is critically dependent upon consumers' willingness to conduct economic transactions online. However, lack of consumer faith in the banking regulatory system, the failure of the EU to complete a comprehensive debt management scheme, continues to result in a lack of consumer confidence and therefore has an impact on their willingness to conduct economic activity.

During the current economic downturn Sample Company has achieved a reasonable level of success. With large numbers of people out of work they have seen a steady increase in new start-up businesses throughout Ireland and, due to the low set up costs and accessibility to a huge market, eCommerce websites have become increasingly popular. Consequently, Sample Company have experienced an increase in demand for their products as small business start-ups can provide secure payment options to their customers through the adoption of the Sample Company payments engine at a reasonable cost.

"There is huge uncertainty about the Euro's future arising from the accumulated failure to tackle debt sustainability, banking stability and capital adequacy in a comprehensive way". (Irish Times Editorial, Oct 28th, 2011)

It has been noted that small companies relaying on the domestic Irish market are the ones struggling at the moment due to fall off in demand, the cost base they are trying to cover in terms of margin,

and funding difficulties (Accountancy Ireland, 2011). The nature of the Sample Company business insulates them from this restriction in that the product they are producing potentially has a global marketplace and so they are somewhat insulated from domestic market restrictions. However, despite the potential of a global market for the Sample Company product, the Sample Company still focuses primarily on Ireland and the UK as their main target markets.

Since Sample Company do a large portion of their business in the UK they have to deal with a large amount of Sterling. The exchange rate therefore can have either a positive or negative effect on the revenue stream coming into the business. Uncertainty in relation to the Euro and the consequent unstable movements in Euro/Sterling exchange rates are a significant source of economic uncertainty for the Sample Company. Recent moves towards the development of a stabilisation pact among the EU member states are a welcome development for the Sample Company.

As Sample Company is only in its 6th operating year and most of this time has been spent operating in a recessionary economic climate they currently reinvest all profits back into the Sample Company. However, they are hoping in the next year to be in the position to reinvest a portion of their profits into other sectors of the market. This will aid the development of an all-in-one eCommerce solution, in addition to their payments solution, which will provide everything necessary for their customers to conduct business online. Such a development will be dependent to some extent on the economic uncertainty with the Euro zone being reduced or eliminated, a more stable exchange rate between the Euro and sterling, and hopefully, a general increase in the level of economic activity within the overall European community.

Conclusion

During the course of this assignment, it became clear that many of the components of the SPECTACLES model involve considerable overlap. Given this considerable overlap, it is apparent that it is not just the individual factors that need to be considered but their combined effect (Gallagher, 2011). Given that the boundaries between the internal and external environments of an organisation can be blurred (Cartwright, 2001), one of the main difficulties encountered was the determination of what should be included in the individual components, in particular, differentiating between the political, economic and legal components.

A SPECTACLES analysis can be used for business and strategic planning, marketing planning, organisational change, business and product development and research reports.
To be effective, organisations need to carry out an analysis on a regular basis in the hope that they will spot trends before their competitors, thus providing competitive advantage (Morrison and Daniels, 2010).

In terms of the SPECTACLES analysis conducted on Sample Company, the key issues which arise may be summarised as follows:

Social	Despite the current problems in Ireland, it is estimated that Sample Company will continue to grow. This is due to the high level of education and internet usage among Irish consumers. The combination of State assistance for new business start-ups and high levels of redundancy payments has resulted in high levels of new Internet businesses, most of which require payments processing systems.
Political	While the existing political stability within the Irish context is favourable to companies operating within the Irish environment, it is the likely impact of the European political context on Ireland which will give rise to political uncertainty, and potentially undermine such favourable conditions.
Economic	Company have experienced an increase in demand for their products as small business start-ups can provide secure payment options to their customers through the adoption of the Sample Company payments engine at a reasonable cost. However, Sample Company is critically dependent upon consumers' willingness to conduct economic transactions online. Lack of consumer faith in the banking regulatory system and the failure of the EU to complete a comprehensive debt management scheme, will continue to result in a lack of consumer confidence and

	therefore has an impact on their willingness to conduct economic activity. In addition, uncertainty in relation to the Euro and the consequent unstable movements in Euro/Sterling exchange rates are a significant source of economic uncertainty for the Sample Company.
Cultural	The culture within Sample Company encourages innovation and new ideas. All employees are treated as an integral part of the organisation, including those who are in partnership or have formed alliances with the Sample Company. It is anticipated that Sample Company will continue to attract partnerships in this manner.
Technological	Company should continue to build on the movement towards a 'cashless' society. Sample Company will strive to be at the forefront of technological innovation. It needs to increase its usage of social media to attract both new customers and partners.
Aesthetic	Company continues to be conscious of its image and needs to build on the favourable impact achieved following its 'Shift Happens' event earlier in 2011. While, the strategic decision to promote its 'white-labelling' service will increase profitability, it will reduce its external profile in some sectors.
Customers	Company's customers are start-up businesses who have come into existence due to necessity in recessionary times
Legal	Company needs to continue to adhere to all the legal regulations and be aware of the regulations in countries where it hopes to expand.
Environmental	Company's environmental impact continues to be kept to a minimum.
Sectoral	Company holds a niche position for small businesses in the Financial Services Sector and continues to differentiate itself by offering customised e-payments to small business and individual entrepreneurs.

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Appendix A

Questions adapted from Cartwright (2001)

Social

What social groupings do customers belong to?
What is the current educational level of the workforce?
What is the anticipated educational level of the workforce?
Are there social issues that are likely to impact on the Sample Company's plans?
In what way will demographic trends impact the Sample Company?

Political

Are there any political issues that will impact the Sample Company?
What relationships (if any) does the Sample Company have with politicians and political parties?
Will developments such as the EMY impact directly on the Sample Company?
How has the current crisis impacted the Sample Company?

Economic

What is the financial position in respect of assets, worth and liquidity?
What effect does exchange rates have on the Sample Company?
How does the Sample Company invest its excess money?

Cultural

What is the Sample Company culture?
Is there any clashes between the Sample Company culture and those of the stakeholders?
What national cultures does Sample Company operate within?

Technical

What current technological advances are likely to benefit Sample Company?
What costs will Sample Company incur in putting the latest technology in place?
Will staff need retraining for new technologies?
Is there any danger of customer resistance to introducing new technologies?

Aesthetic

How does Sample Company currently interact with customers?
How does Sample Company attract new customers?
How does organisational body language (location/building; security; convenience; communications; ambience) affect customer relationships?
How could Sample Company improve its external image?
Does branding have implications for the organisation?

Customers

What is the nature of the customer base?
What customer needs does the product/service range meet?
What product/service developments will meet anticipated needs?

Legal

What is the effect of current legislation in the areas of : Contract Employment Rights Health and Safety Consumer Protection Competition

Environment

How does Sample Company impact on the environment?
What environmental legislation is relevant to Sample Company?
How does Sample Company deal with waste and toxic product (toner etc)
How much material does Sample Company recycle?
What effect might global warming have on Sample Company ?

Sectoral

What business is Sample Company actually in?
What sector of the environment does it operate in – public, private, voluntary?
Who are the main competitors?
What unique selling points does Sample Company have?
What unique selling points do competitors have?
Is there a danger of substitution?
Is there a danger of new entrants?
Is there a danger of re-forming [competitor sells their business and the buyer enters the market without any barriers to entry]?
Is there a danger of re-entry [organisations who left the market returning]?
Is there collaboration between Sample Company and its competitors?
Is Sample Company growing – how is this happening?